

Squark Dashboard — Phase 1 User Guide

How every module works and how to use it · August 2026

This guide covers every part of the dashboard that is built and running. Each section explains what the module is, what it is for, and the steps to use it. You will only see the modules your role allows, so some parts of this guide may not apply to you.

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1 Logging in and finding your way

You sign in with your work email and your own password. If an admin has just created or reset your account, the system asks you to set a new password before you can change anything.

The first time you log in, you are asked to **complete your profile** — contact number, address, date of birth and emergency contact. You cannot skip this. Personal details are visible only to Admin and HR, not to your colleagues.

The **left sidebar** is your main menu. It shows only the modules your role can open, so two people may see different menus. Press **Ctrl + B** to collapse or expand it. At the top of the sidebar you have **Search** (find any project, task or person) and the **bell icon** for notifications. Clicking a notification takes you straight to the item it is about.

Some actions — adding people, changing roles — ask for an extra **org passcode** on top of your password. This is a safety check for changes that affect everyone. It is remembered for a short while so you are not asked repeatedly.

If you leave the dashboard open and idle for a few hours, you are logged out automatically.

2 Home

Home is your landing page and it changes to match your role — a manager sees approvals and team numbers, an analyst sees their own tasks and hours.

On it you will find:

- **Punch In / Punch Out** — mark your attendance without going to the Attendance page
- **My Performance** — completion rate, on-time rate, hours logged and overdue tasks
- **My Tasks** — what is due, split by open and completed

- **Projects** and **Project Status** — the projects you are on and how they are progressing

Every card has a link in its corner that opens the full module.

3 Projects

A project is one piece of client work — one search, one study, one report. Everything else in the system hangs off it: tasks, hours, files and discussion.

Creating a project

1. Go to **Projects** and click **New Project**.
2. Choose the **Type** — this is required. The nine types are Infringement Search, Novelty Search, Invalidity Search, FTO Search, Landscape Search, Patent Monetization, Reverse Engineering, Risk & Strategy, and General/Other. You can also add a new type of your own and type its task list, one task per line.
3. Pick the **patent** the work is about, if there is one. Search by patent ID. The client is filled in from the patent, so you never have to type it.
4. Enter a **Title** and a short **Description**.
5. Choose the **Technology domain** — the field the work sits in (Medical, Automobile, Source Code, Cloud/Server, Advertisement, or one your team has added).
6. Set the **Priority**, **Start Date** and **Deadline**.
7. Save. The project is created straight away and its standard task list is added for you.

The **type** and the **technology domain** are two different things. The type is the kind of study (an FTO search). The domain is the subject (a medical device). The same FTO search can be about a pacemaker or a gearbox.

Inside a project

Open any project and you get these tabs:

- **Overview** — dates, progress, team, and the project's PID
- **Task List** — all tasks, grouped, where most work happens
- **Timesheets** — every hour logged against this project
- **Board** — the same tasks as a drag-and-drop Kanban board
- **Gantt** — the timeline view, with today marked
- **Capacity** — who on the team is free or busy (if your role allows)
- **Files** — documents and images attached to the project
- **Issues** — problems raised during the work
- **Activity** — a history of who changed what
- **Discussions** — the project chat

Finding and finishing projects

The Projects list can be sorted and filtered by technology domain and phase. When work is done, use **Complete** — you are asked for the date you delivered to the client, the working hours and the actual hours it really took. Hours are suggested from the timesheets, and you can correct them. **Close** moves a project into the Closed section to get it out of the way, and **Reopen** brings it back if the client returns.

4 Project IDs (PID)

Every project carries a PID such as `SQ_26_27_001`. `SQ` is the company, `26_27` is the financial year, and `001` is the serial number. The PID is how the team refers to a matter in conversation, in

timesheets and in reports.

An important rule: **a returning client keeps the same PID**. New work for the same client becomes a new round under that same PID rather than a fresh number, so all the work for one client stays together.

How you get a PID depends on your role. If you have permission, you click **Generate PID** and one is reserved for you. If you do not, you submit a **PID request**; the person who handles PIDs sees it in their queue, assigns the number, and you are notified.

Admins have a **PID Ledger** in the sidebar listing every PID ever issued and its state: Working, Completed, Reserved or Discontinued. Use it to check whether a client already has a number before creating anything new.

5 Patents and Clients

Super Admin only.

This is the confidential area. Client names and real patent numbers are commercially sensitive, so the system keeps them apart from everyday project work.

Each patent is stored under a short code such as `Pat_MLK_001`. That code is what everyone else sees in project screens. The **real patent number is hidden** and is shown only when you click to reveal it and enter the passcode.

To add patents, either enter the numbers directly (one per line) or upload the patent document — the file name is read and the patent record is created from it. You can attach PDFs and other media to a patent, and replace a document later. Client codes can be renamed if a client's short code changes.

6 Tasks and Sub-tasks

Tasks are the steps of the work. When you create a project from a type, its standard tasks are already there; you add, rename or remove as the matter needs.

Click any task to open its panel on the right. Changes there **save automatically** — there is no Save button. In the panel you set:

- **Description** — what has to be done
- **Staffing** — who is doing the work. Each person is added with a role: **PM**, **Reviewer** or **Analyst**, and with estimated hours. Hours are optional, so a reviewer can be added at zero hours.
- **Status, priority and deadline**
- **Sub-tasks** — smaller steps inside the task, which you can add, rename, tick off and delete
- **Comments and activity** — discussion and a record of changes

The panel also shows **Assigned by**, so it is always clear who handed the work over.

7 My Tasks

My Tasks collects your work from every project into one list, so you do not have to open projects one by one to see what is due.

Filter by **All**, **In Progress** or **Completed**. Each row shows the project, the deadline and a coloured dot for priority (Low, Medium, High, Critical). Click **Mark complete** to finish a task, and click a completed task again to reopen it if it was closed too early.

8 Timesheets

Timesheets record where your hours went. They feed project costing, the performance figures and the daily digest, so they need to be filled in honestly and on time.

Logging time

1. Open **Timesheets** and click **Log Time**.
2. Select the **project** by its PID, then the **task** you worked on. Only tasks assigned to you are listed.
3. Enter the **hours** — anything from 0.25 to 24 — and the date.
4. Mark it **Billable** or **Non-bill**. This is your own choice on your own time.
5. Add a short note if it helps, and save.

For time that is not against a project task, choose **Client call** (then pick the PID the call was about) or **Other** for non-project time.

The calendar and catching up

Your month is shown as a colour calendar so gaps are obvious at a glance: **green** for a full day logged, **amber** for a partial day, and **red** where too little or nothing is recorded. Click any day to see or add entries. The system also reminds you when time has not been filled in.

Backdating rules

- Up to **1 month** old — log it freely.
- **1 to 3 months** old — allowed, but it goes to a Super Admin for approval.
- Over **3 months** old — closed; it cannot be logged.

The **Backfill** card on the Timesheets page is where you raise and track those approval requests.

9 Attendance

Attendance records the days you worked. It has four tabs: **Overview**, **Leaves**, **Holidays**, and **Team** for those who manage people.

Punching in and out

Click **Punch In** when you start and **Punch Out** when you finish. You can do this from Attendance or straight from Home. Your **location is recorded** with the punch and shown as an area name, so location access must be allowed in your browser.

A day of under four hours is counted as a **Half Day** automatically. If you forget to punch out, the system closes the day for you.

Your calendar

The month view marks each day as Present, Half Day, Absent, On Leave, Holiday, Weekly Off, Work From Home or Not Marked, with late arrivals flagged. Below it, the **Attendance Log** lists your in and out times day by day. You can view a full year of history and export it to CSV.

Fixing a wrong day (regularisation)

If a day is wrong — you forgot to punch, you were late for a genuine reason, or you were out on client work — click that day and raise a **regularisation**. Pick the reason: Missed punch, Late, On duty, Work from home, Past midnight or Other, and explain briefly. It goes to HR, who approve or reject it. Your own pending requests are listed so you can track or cancel them.

10 Leaves

Leave is taken in **whole days and half days only** — there is no hourly leave. A half day is either the **First Half** or the **Second Half** of one date.

1. Open **Attendance → Leaves** and click **Apply for Leave**.
2. Choose the leave type and the dates.
3. Choose **Full Day** or **Half Day**. For a half day, say which half.
4. Give a reason. Depending on the leave, you may be asked for an alternate contact, an alternate address, and the colleague covering for you.
5. Attach a file if one is needed, then submit.

Your request goes to the right approver and you are notified when it is decided. You can **cancel** a request you no longer need.

The **balance card** shows what you have, written plainly as **Credit** (what was added) and **Debit** (what you have used), so the number is easy to check. Only one leave request can cover a given day. The **Leave Planner** lets you map out time off in advance.

11 Comp-off

Comp-off is time off earned by working on a weekend or a public holiday.

On your attendance calendar, weekend and holiday cells are clickable. Click the day you worked and choose **Claim comp-off**. Say how much you worked — a **half day** or a **full day** — and attach evidence of the work. HR reviews the claim, and once approved the balance is **credited** to you. When you later take that time off, it appears as a **debit** on the same balance card.

12 Work From Home

Working from home is requested in advance, not decided at the moment you punch in.

Raise a **WFH request** with the start and end dates and a reason. It goes to HR or an Admin to approve. Once approved, when you punch in on those dates your day is automatically marked **Work From Home** — you do not have to do anything else.

A single request can cover up to 31 days; longer arrangements are made with HR directly. You cannot have approved leave and work from home on the same day — you are either off or working.

13 Expenses

Expenses are work costs you paid for yourself and want reimbursed.

1. Open **Expenses** and start a new claim.
2. Pick the category: Travel, Accommodation, Meals, Software, Supplies, Client or Other.
3. Enter the **amount** and a short description of what it was for.
4. **Attach the bill or receipt.**
5. Submit.

The claim sits as **Pending** until an approver acts, then becomes **Approved** or **Rejected**, and finally **Reimbursed** once paid. Admins and HR are notified when a new claim arrives. **My expenses** shows your own claims and you can cancel one that is still pending.

14 Team Capacity

For managers and delivery leads.

Capacity answers one question: **who is free and who is loaded?** It is a grid of people against dates, and each day is marked **Free**, **Busy**, **Leave**, **Pending leave**, **Holiday**, **Comp-off** or **Absent**.

You can:

- Filter by project team to look at one matter's people only

- Change the date range, or look back at **actual attendance over the past 30 days** instead of the plan
- Click a person to see their tasks and load in detail
- **Extend a deadline** or **reassign a task** directly from the board when someone is unexpectedly out

A strip at the top lists who is on leave and which holidays fall inside the window you are looking at, so a plan is not made on top of days nobody is working.

15 Performance

Performance turns the work already recorded — tasks finished, deadlines met, hours logged — into a picture of how things are going. Nothing is typed in by hand here; it is all worked out from the system.

Your own view shows your **completion rate**, **on-time rate**, **hours logged** and **activity**, with a trend over time and a contribution heat map showing your busy and quiet periods.

Leadership additionally gets the **organisation view**: project progress, top contributors, and rankings, as charts with clear labels and colour keys.

Every metric has an information icon next to it explaining exactly how the number is worked out, so there is no guessing about what a score means. You can change the time window to look at a longer or shorter period.

16 Calendar

The Calendar brings your deadlines, meetings, approved leave and company holidays into one month view, so you can see what is coming without opening each module.

The **Team Calendar** tab shows the whole team together — useful before promising a date or planning a review. It runs as a scrollable timeline covering one month back and three months ahead, with holidays marked, and weeks starting on Monday.

17 Reports

Reports is the read-only summary of delivery across all projects, for sharing outside the dashboard. It lists projects with their phase (Planning, Active, On Hold, Completed, Archived), priority, progress and average completion, and you can filter on any of these. Task-level detail sits under each project. Use the export menu to download as **CSV** for a spreadsheet or **PDF** to send on.

18 Daily Digest

Super Admin only.

The digest is an end-of-day summary of the whole organisation, produced automatically at **10 pm**. It covers the day's projects, the hours each person logged, and the deadlines coming up.

Open the **Daily Digest** page to read it, click through to a full detail screen for any line, and export it. The time it runs can be changed in settings.

19 People

People is the team directory. The **All Members** tab lists everyone with their photo, role and designation; the **Departments** tab groups them by department — Leadership, Management, Consulting, Research, Product and Human Resources.

Click a person to open their page: their designation, their reporting line, the projects they are on, and a link to their roles and permissions. Everyone can upload their own profile photo.

Personal details — home address, date of birth, next of kin — are shown only to Admin, Super Admin and HR. Other colleagues do not receive that information at all.

20 Company

Company is the shared, non-project side of the organisation. It has four tabs:

- **Feed** — company announcements. Anyone can read them; those with permission can post, edit and attach a document.
- **Recognition** — appreciation given to colleagues, such as Above & Beyond, with the reason recorded.
- **Policies** — the HR policy library. Open a policy to read it and acknowledge it; HR can see who has and has not read each one.
- **Directory** — the org chart and reporting lines, plus upcoming birthdays and work anniversaries.

21 Appraisals

Appraisals are the structured performance reviews. HR opens a **cycle** covering a period, and everyone in it goes through the same three steps.

1. **Self-assessment** — you write your own review against your goals and submit it. Until you do, your review shows as awaiting self-assessment.
2. **Manager review** — your reviewer reads it, adds their assessment and submits.
3. **Acknowledge** — you read the manager's review and acknowledge it, which closes the appraisal.

My reviews shows your own appraisals past and present. Managers see the reviews waiting on them, and HR sees the full roster for the cycle and who is holding it up.

22 Admin

For Admins and Super Admins.

The Admin area is where the system itself is managed.

- **Users** — create a team member (work email required), deactivate someone who has left, and reset a password. A user whose password was reset must set a new one before they can change anything.
- **Roles and permissions** — a matrix screen showing every role against every permission. There are eight roles: Super Admin, Admin, Manager, Senior Consultant, Consultant, Senior Research Associate, HR and Employee. You can create roles, edit what each one can do, and grant an individual an exception.
- **PID Ledger** — every PID issued, with its state and the project it belongs to.
- **Audit Log** — a permanent record of who changed what and when. It cannot be edited or deleted, and it is the place to look when something needs explaining.

Changes here affect everyone, so most of them ask for the org passcode as well as your password.